WELL-BEING

Sleep during recovery

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

Why does sleep matter?

Good sleep supports your health and daily activities. Most adults generally need seven to nine hours, though needs vary. Too little good-quality sleep over time is linked with high blood pressure and heart disease. Tell your care team if pain, worry, medicines, or breathing problems disturb your sleep. [1,3]

Look for a pattern

A short sleep diary can help you describe the problem. Note when you go to bed, when you get up, and whether you wake during the night. Add how rested you feel the next day. You can also note questions about a new medicine or discomfort. Keep the record simple enough to maintain. It is a discussion aid, not a diagnosis.

Try a steady routine

A regular bedtime and waking time, a calm wind-down period, and a quiet sleeping space may support better sleep. Ask how daytime rest and approved activity should fit your recovery. Consider whether evening screen use or caffeine is affecting your routine. Start with a change you can repeat. If you work shifts or share a crowded room, explain those limits rather than accepting an unrealistic schedule. [1,4]

Mention snoring and daytime sleepiness

Loud snoring, breathing pauses noticed by another person, or excessive daytime sleepiness can be reasons to discuss possible sleep apnea. A clinician can assess whether testing is needed. Snoring alone does not confirm a diagnosis, and an app cannot replace assessment. If you already have prescribed treatment for a sleep disorder, ask how to continue it during rehabilitation or after a hospital admission. [2]

Do not mask a breathing problem

Waking short of breath or needing a change in sleeping position because breathing feels difficult deserves medical attention, particularly if you have heart failure. Describe what is new rather than assuming the problem is anxiety. Severe breathing difficulty, chest pressure, or fainting needs emergency care. Do not wait to finish a sleep diary or try a new bedtime habit before seeking help.

Check before using sleep products

Ask your doctor or pharmacist before taking a sleep medicine, supplement, or herbal product. Tell them about your heart medicines and any alcohol use. Products sold without a prescription can still carry risks or interact with treatment. If a prescribed medicine seems to disturb sleep, ask for advice instead of changing the dose or timing yourself. Keep the packaging available for the discussion.

Bring a practical question

Explain your main sleep problem and ask what to do next. Confirm when to review the plan and which symptoms need earlier attention. If an agreed change does not help, tell your team rather than continuing to experiment alone.

References

1. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (2022, March 24). Get enough good-quality sleep. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/heart-healthy-living/sleep

2. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (n.d.). Sleep apnea symptoms. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/sleep-apnea/symptoms

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Healthy sleep. https://medlineplus.gov/healthysleep.html

4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (n.d.). About sleep. https://www.cdc.gov/sleep/about/index.html

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